

■ GARGANO — UMBRA FOREST, MONTE SANT'ANGELO, SAN GIOVANNI ROTONDO

Voice: Fra' Salvatore, 73 years old, friar of the Sanctuary of Monte Sant'Angelo, born in San Giovanni Rotondo

■ GARGANO — UMBRA FOREST, MONTE SANT'ANGELO, SAN GIOVANNI ROTONDO

Voice: Fra' Salvatore, 73 years old, friar of the Sanctuary of Monte Sant'Angelo, born in San Giovanni Rotondo

CAP. 1 — INTRO: THREE PLACES, ONE PATH

These aren't three destinations.

They're a path.

The forest, the grotto, the monastery. Nature, the archangel, the saint. Three things that appear separate on a map but on this promontory form something unlike anywhere else in the world.

My name is Fra' Salvatore. Seventy-three years old. I was born in San Giovanni Rotondo in 1952 — four years before Padre Pio died. My parents would bring me to his mass every Sunday. I saw him as a child, I don't remember — but my parents used to say he was a small man with gloves on his hands and a presence you felt before you saw him.

For thirty years I have served the Sanctuary of Monte Sant'Angelo. I walk the Umbra Forest every week. I know this land the way you know a book you've read hundreds of times.

I'll tell you what I see. Not the version written for tourist guides. The real one.

CAP. 2 — THE UMBRA FOREST: THE PREPARATION

Before going to the Archangel's grotto, go into the forest.

It wasn't my idea. It's what medieval pilgrims did. They arrived on foot from the Apennines, crossed the forest, descended to Monte Sant'Angelo. The forest was the

preparation. The passage between the ordinary world and the sacred place.

The Umbra Forest is eleven thousand hectares of primeval woodland. Beeches, oaks, yews, hollies — trees no one has ever systematically cut down. Centuries of free growth. Trunks two metres across. Branches so high that sunlight never reaches the ground.

When I enter the forest, I always stop at the same spot — where the trees close over the path and everything suddenly turns to silence and shadow. It's a threshold. I feel it physically. As if you were stepping into a different space.

Medieval pilgrims had a name for it. They called it the sacred wood. Because they understood — certain forests are not just trees. They are places with their own logic, their own time, their own silence.

CAP. 3 — THE ANIMALS OF THE FOREST

The forest is full of life.

Red deer, fallow deer, roe deer, wild boar, foxes, badgers. Dozens of bird species — the black woodpecker, the peregrine falcon, the hen harrier. And the otter, which has returned to the streams of the Gargano after decades of absence.

I always walk in the early morning. Half past five, six o'clock. When the animals are still moving and the hikers haven't arrived yet.

I've seen the stag cross the path in front of me three times in thirty years. Each time it stopped, looked at me, then disappeared into the trees. I don't know if it was the same animal each time. It doesn't matter.

The forest is a place of contemplation. Not of sport. Not of fitness. Those who run through it have no idea what they've just passed through. Those who walk it slowly, in silence, come out different from how they went in.

CAP. 4 — MONTE SANT'ANGELO: THE GROTTA

Monte Sant'Angelo sits at six hundred and ninety-six metres above sea level.

You get there from the forest or from the sea — by car, today. Once, people came on foot. Pilgrims from Ireland, from Germany, from Spain. They walked for weeks. Months.

The Sanctuary of San Michele Arcangelo is the second oldest Christian pilgrimage site in the world. The first is Jerusalem. The second is here.

Tradition holds that the Archangel Michael appeared in this grotto in 490 AD. Three apparitions in three different years. During the third, on September 29th, 493, he left the mark of his cloak on the rock. The grotto became a sanctuary.

When you descend the eighty-six steps and enter the cavern, the first thing you feel is the cold. Twelve degrees all year round, summer and winter alike. Then your eyes adjust to the darkness and you see the statue of the Archangel on the altar — gilded bronze, wings spread wide, sword raised.

Fifteen hundred years of prayer in this rock. You feel it. It isn't suggestion. It's something physical.

CAP. 5 — THE PILGRIMS: WHO CAME AND WHY

Charlemagne stopped here in the year 787.

Not in passing — he came deliberately. He walked the route from the plain up to the grotto on foot. An emperor descending on foot, like any ordinary pilgrim.

Francis of Assisi came in 1216. But he stopped outside. He wouldn't enter — he considered himself too much of a sinner to enter a place consecrated by the Archangel himself. He remained kneeling on the threshold. As a penance, he carved a cross into the rock. That cross is still visible today.

The Normans, when they conquered southern Italy in the eleventh century, venerated Michael the Archangel as the protector of their enterprise. They built the outer bell tower that you can still see today. The stone tower visible from the entire valley below.

The Lombards before them considered Michael the protector of battle. Every Lombard warrior leaving for war passed through this grotto first. As people still do today — in different forms, but they still do.

CAP. 6 — SAN GIOVANNI ROTONDO: PADRE PIO

San Giovanni Rotondo is thirty-five kilometres from Monte Sant'Angelo.

It is the sanctuary of Padre Pio. Seven million pilgrims every year. The second most visited Catholic pilgrimage site in the world, after Lourdes.

I was born in this town. I've lived here my whole life. And I must be honest with you — what you see today bears little resemblance to the place where Padre Pio lived.

Padre Pio arrived in San Giovanni Rotondo in 1916. The town was poor, isolated, hard to reach. There wasn't even a paved road. Pilgrims arrived on mule-back.

Today there's the new Sanctuary — designed by Renzo Piano, inaugurated in 2004, capable of holding thirty thousand people. It's large, it's modern, it's necessary given the numbers.

But the place worth seeing is the old church — the small one, where Padre Pio celebrated mass in the morning. Where people waited for hours to confess to him. That church still has that quality — small, intimate, human.

He received the stigmata in 1918. He bore them for fifty years. He died in 1968 — and that morning, witnesses say, the stigmata had vanished. The skin was intact.

CAP. 7 — WHO PADRE PIO WAS: BEYOND RELIGIOUS TOURISM

Let me tell you what my parents used to say about him.

My mother went to his five o'clock mass. Summer and winter alike. In any weather. She would queue outside the church from midnight.

She said it wasn't the mass itself. It was him. The way he celebrated — slowly, as if every word had weight. Sometimes he would stop and weep at the altar. Sometimes the mass lasted three hours. No one left.

People brought him letters with their petitions. Healings, protection, graces. He read them, replied, prayed. He received hundreds of letters a day.

He was also severe. In confession he turned away people who weren't ready. He had no patience for those who came out of curiosity. He could tell the difference.

My father went once, to confess to him. He never told me what Padre Pio said to him. But he came back different. I could see it in his face when he walked through the door. He was another man.

CAP. 8 — THE CONNECTION BETWEEN THE THREE PLACES

There is something few people notice.

The Umbra Forest, Monte Sant'Angelo, San Giovanni Rotondo — all three sit on the same promontory. Less than forty kilometres apart.

The forest runs through the middle, like a green spine. Monte Sant'Angelo stands on the heights to the east. San Giovanni Rotondo lies on the western side, facing the Tavoliere plain.

Medieval pilgrims visited all three. It wasn't religious tourism — it was a route. They began at Monte Sant'Angelo because the Archangel was older. They crossed the forest. They descended toward the plain.

Today you can do it by car in a single day. But the meaning is the same — these are not three separate things. They are one single experience. Nature, ancient sacred, recent sacred. The Gargano gives you all three in the same day.

CAP. 9 — PRACTICAL ADVICE

For the Umbra Forest: go in the early morning. Before nine. The car parks fill up fast in summer. The best trails are the long ones — at least two hours of walking. Not the quick loop from the car park. That isn't the forest.

For Monte Sant'Angelo: avoid the midday hours in summer. The Archangel's Grotto is open all day, but the heat outside is unbearable from eleven until four. Early morning or late afternoon — the light is different, the crowds are thinner.

For San Giovanni Rotondo: visit the old church before the new sanctuary. Feel the difference in scale. Understand where everything began. Then see the new one if you like — Renzo Piano's architecture is worth a look. But the old one first.

CAP. 10 — THE UMBRA FOREST: THE ANIMALS YOU DON'T SEE

The Umbra Forest is full of animals.

Almost no one sees them.

Not because they aren't there — they are, and in significant numbers. But the forest is dense, silent, and animals know when humans are nearby.

The fallow deer of the Gargano are an indigenous subspecies — the Gargano fallow deer, smaller and darker than those on the mainland. There are also wild boar — many of them, and not always shy. Encountering them on a trail is not uncommon. They usually bolt. Usually.

The beeches of the Umbra Forest are centuries old. Some are over five hundred years old. The yews — the trees, not the animals — are even older. A yew can live a thousand years. Walking alongside one is an act of humility.

CAP. 11 — MONTE SANT'ANGELO AND THE LOMBARDS

The sanctuary of Monte Sant'Angelo has been a UNESCO World Heritage Site since 2011.

Not on its own — together with other Lombard sites across Italy. The recognition is for the "Longobards in Italy: Places of Power." Monte Sant'Angelo is among them because something important began here.

The Lombards arrived in Italy in 568. The Duke of Benevento, in the seventh century, spread the cult of Saint Michael throughout Lombard Europe. From this grotto grew a network of sanctuaries dedicated to the archangel — Mont Saint-Michel in Normandy, the Sacra di San Michele in Piedmont. All connected to this rock.

CAP. 12 — PADRE PIO: THE INVESTIGATIONS AND THE CANONIZATION

I don't often say these things.

But the story of Padre Pio is not only devotion. It is also a story of investigations, of doubts, of a man who was suspected and scrutinized by the very Church that would later canonize him.

The stigmata appeared in 1918. The Vatican sent doctors and commissions. For years Padre Pio was forbidden from celebrating mass in public. Church authorities were divided — some believed, some did not.

John Paul II beatified him in 1999. He canonized him in 2002. Today he is one of the most venerated saints in the world. Over seven million pilgrims a year to San Giovanni Rotondo.

I have my own faith. But I think every pilgrim must bring their own, not mine.

CAP. 13 — THE PILGRIMS' RITUAL

Every day, dozens of coaches arrive at San Giovanni Rotondo.

The pilgrims step off carrying empty bottles. They go to the blessed-water fountains. They fill them. They enter the church. They pray before the body of the saint. They buy the souvenirs. They get back on the coach.

It is a ritual that has repeated identically for decades. No different from the medieval pilgrims who came on foot from half of Europe — the transport has changed, the impulse has not.

Simple people come, educated people, desperate people, curious people. Everyone brings something. Everyone seeks something. On this promontory, something draws faith like a magnet.

CAP. 14 — HOW TO PLAN THE ROUTE

To visit all three places in one day, you need a car.

By car the logical route is: morning in the Umbra Forest, midday at Monte Sant'Angelo, afternoon in San Giovanni Rotondo. About three and a half hours of driving in total, spread across the whole day.

For the Umbra Forest: wear proper footwear — the trails aren't always dry. In summer the forest is cooler than the coast, but the humidity still finds you.

For Monte Sant'Angelo: cover your shoulders and knees to enter the grotto. It is an active place of worship, not a museum. The village around it is worth a walk — extraordinary views over the gulf.

For San Giovanni Rotondo: go on a weekday if you can. Weekends are overcrowded. The old church is more intimate than the new one. But Renzo Piano's architecture deserves a moment.

CAP. 15 — THE GROTTA: HOW YOU DESCEND

The sanctuary of San Michele is not at the top of the mountain.

It is inside the mountain.

You descend a staircase — eighty-six steps, cut into the rock, going down. The air cools with every step. The light fades. When you reach the grotto, the temperature is around twelve degrees all year round.

The grotto has been venerated since the time of the Lombards — perhaps before. On the wall to the left of the altar there is an impression in the rock. Tradition says it is the imprint of Saint Michael's cloak from the third apparition. In 490 AD.

I've entered it hundreds of times. I never get used to the sudden cold, the way the silence changes, the smell of ancient stone. Even those who don't believe feel something, in that place. I don't know what to call it — perhaps it's just the rock and the darkness. But it's something.

CAP. 16 — THE FOOD OF THE SACRED GARGANO

After the grotto, after the pilgrims, after the prayers — you eat.

Monte Sant'Angelo has its own dishes. The sugar-glazed tarallo — sweet, crunchy, eaten for centuries as a votive offering and as a snack. The focaccia with tomato — the real kind, with raw tomato on top, oil poured generously.

In the restaurants around the sanctuary you'll find lamb — the Gargano has always been a land of shepherds and transhumance. Grilled lamb, or braised with olives, is what has always been eaten here.

I eat little — monastic life doesn't accustom you to abundance. But when I can, I stop at the village market. The cheeses of the Gargano — caciocotta, smoked scamorza — are simple things made well. Simplicity is a form of respect, in the kitchen as in prayer.

CAP. 17 — THE UMBRA FOREST: TRAILS AND SEASONS

The Umbra Forest changes with the seasons — and each season is radically different from the last.

In spring the undergrowth bursts open. Flowers, fresh green, birds singing from dawn until dusk. It's the best time to walk — cool but not cold, bright but not blinding.

In summer the forest means shade and coolness — a refuge when the coast is at thirty-eight degrees. Many people come for exactly that. But bring water — the trails have no fountains.

In autumn the beeches turn red and orange. If you come in October, the woodland looks painted. That's not rhetoric. It really is.

In winter the forest is nearly deserted. Snow often falls on Monte Sant'Angelo — something the people on the coast find hard to believe. But the Gargano is high, and the cold comes. The bare beeches, snow between the branches, total silence — that is the forest I love most.

CAP. 18 — SAN MARCO IN LAMIS AND THE SPIRITUAL GARGANO

There is another place on this Gargano that deserves a mention.

San Marco in Lamis.

A town in the interior, less known than the others. But with a Franciscan monastery — the convent of Sant'Antonio di Padova — that was already a place of spiritual life before Padre Pio. And with an Easter procession, the Processione delle Fracchie, one of the oldest and most intense in all of Puglia.

The fracchie are tree trunks that are burned in procession on the night of Good Friday. Enormous torches — sometimes three metres tall. The town descends into the streets in silence, carrying these flames. The heat, the smoke, the darkness all around. It is something very ancient.

The Gargano isn't only sea and beaches. It is also this — fire, silence, faith, night.

CAP. 19 — THE GARGANO FROM ABOVE: THE VIEW FROM MONTE SANT'ANGELO

From Monte Sant'Angelo you can see the entire gulf.

The town sits at eight hundred metres — high, above everything. From the belvedere you can see Manfredonia below, the gulf opening toward Bari, the salt flats of Margherita shining like a distant mirror. On clear days you can see the Tremiti Islands — green

shapes on the horizon.

It is one of the most beautiful views in Puglia. No photograph does it justice. You have to be there — feel the cold air even in summer, listen to the silence, look out as far as the eye can reach.

Medieval pilgrims climbed for days on foot to arrive here. Then they saw this view. I understand why they felt they had arrived at God's doorstep. With that effort in their bodies, and that beauty before their eyes — it must have been an experience beyond description.

CAP. 20 — SILENCE AS PRACTICE

I live in a place where silence is a practice, not a coincidence.

Monastic life imposes hours of silence. Not silence because there's nothing to say — silence because silence has value in itself. Listening without producing noise. Being present without taking up space.

When I accompany visitors to the grotto, I sometimes ask them to stay silent for five minutes. Not everyone manages. Someone looks at their phone. Someone starts talking after thirty seconds. But someone really stops. And when they come out, I can see it in their face — something has loosened.

I don't know if it's the grotto. I don't know if it's the cold, the stone, the darkness. I know that in certain places silence feels different. And this is one of those places.

CAP. 21 — CLOSING: FRA' SALVATORE SAYS GOODBYE

Seventy-three years old. Born on this promontory. I've never really left it.

People ask me if I don't get tired of always being here. Of seeing the same places every day.

No.

Because every day these places are different. The forest changes with the seasons. The grotto changes with the light. The sanctuary changes with the people who enter it — every day someone arrives who has never been here, and I see on their face the first time. It never grows old.

I'll leave you with something my mother told me when I was young.

She said: the Lord made this place different from the others. I don't know why — perhaps because of the rock, perhaps because of the sea, perhaps for a reason we can't understand. But he made it different. And you can feel it.

She was right. You can still feel it.

This promontory has other faces.

The green sea of Vieste, the trabucchi clinging to the rock between Peschici and the coast, the islands where monks still live, the inland towns that look down over the lake from above. Each has someone to tell its story. Someone who never left.

The Gargano doesn't end here.